Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment

Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Typically performed by: *Shelter Site Manager*
Roles likely to support task: *Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Workers, Client Care*

Considerations

- The first step in Client-First Sheltering is establishing safe and accessible places for displaced people and their pets.
- Some clients may stay in the dormitory overnight, while others may come to the shelter for meals and recovery support – we strive to help everyone needing our assistance.
- Our clients have many cultural backgrounds and value systems that lead to differing levels of concern about privacy and modesty.
- Due to the disaster and communal living, clients will lose some privacy and may need our support and guidance to maintain their dignity.
- Services at shelters is always be provided for people displaced by the disaster including those with disabilities and other access and functional needs, transgender and nonbinary clients, and regardless of pre-disaster housing status or citizenship.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards:**
  - Shelter Site Operations Standards

What to do

When interacting with clients:

- Introduce yourself and your role.
- Treat clients with dignity and respect, strive to meet clients' individual needs, and support them in their own recovery.
  - Address clients by their formal name, or a polite greeting such as, "Good morning, Sir/Ma'am."
  - Communicate with clients regularly to understand their concerns.
  - Listen carefully, show courtesy and empathy, and accommodate them as much as possible.
- Respect the client's privacy.
  - Request permission from the client when you want to help them move or inspect their personal possessions.
  - Red Cross workers are not to pick up or otherwise touch a client's pet.
  - Treat mobility devices as extensions of the client's body and ask before touching.
- Respect the client's independence.
  - Ask clients if they would like help and what would be helpful to them.
  - Allow clients to make their own choices and decisions as often as possible.
- Communicating with clients whose primary language is not English.
  - If possible, assign a worker who speaks the same language as the client.
  - Contact the HQ Sheltering Manager if translation support is needed.
  - Use an online translation application such as Google Translate.
  - Communicate via writing or text messaging when interpreting is not readily available.

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